California creates fund as lifesaver for crime victim services in Stanislaus, other counties

October 2, 2024 | Modesto Bee, The (CA)
Author: Ken Carlson; Staff Writer | Section: News | 381 Words
Page: 3A
OpenURL Link

Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a bill that establishes a long-term funding source for supporting crime victim services in counties like Stanislaus.

Advocacy groups said the new California Crime Victims Fund will provide lifesaving support for people needing shelter after fleeing domestic violence, rape victims who need mental health counseling, victims of child abuse and other individuals.

Those services have relied on federal Victims of Crime Act funding that has dramatically declined over the years. This past year, crime victim groups lobbied hard for a state funding stream to prevent serious cuts to programs in California.

Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, wrote AB 2432, which will create a crime victims fund absorbing fines when corporations are convicted of wrongdoing. The legislation creates a criminal enhancement with an additional fine in misdemeanor and felony cases of white-collar crime.

The court could order a major corporation to pay a maximum $25 million fine. In cases of theft from a person or business entity, the corporation could be ordered to pay two times the value of the money taken, with the funds deposited in the state crime victims fund.

"I am extremely grateful to Gov. Newsom and all the advocates who worked tirelessly for this law to be made possible," May Rico, executive director of Modesto-based Healthy Alternatives to Violent Environments, said in an email Friday. "Like many other agencies, HAVEN has felt the pressure of funding for crime victims in our community not keeping up with the needs of survivors who reach out to us every day."

Rico said she hopes the state fund can grow and provide stable financial support for services.

Nonprofit service providers that assist crime victims have faced staffing cuts and program closures, as the federal VOCA money has dwindled. HAVEN and other groups have made adjustments to continue legal assistance for domestic violence survivors who need restraining orders.

The Stanislaus County District Attorney's office said in May that 87% of funding for its victims services unit came from the federal VOCA source.

The California Partnership to End Domestic Violence said in a news release Friday that building the state crime victims fund will take time, so short-term state funding will be necessary to support programs.

Other groups that supported AB 2432 included the Children's Advocacy Centers of California, the Legal Aid Association of California and ValorUS.

Ken Carlson: 209-578-2321

Copyright (c) 2024 The Modesto Bee

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Carlson, K. (2024, October 2). California creates fund as lifesaver for crime victim services in Stanislaus, other counties*Modesto Bee, The (CA)*, p. 3A. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current:

https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19BF7B8EB32258E8.